CHAPTER 7 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Antietam

The bloodiest single day in American history — and the first time the public saw what a battlefield truly looked like. September 1862.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The bloodiest single day in American history — and the first time the public saw what a battlefield truly looked like. September 1862.

What changes when a nation can finally see its war, instead of only reading about it?

The Bloodiest Day

SEPTEMBER 17, 1862

In September 1862, Confederate General Robert E. Lee invaded the North, marching into Maryland. The two armies collided along Antietam Creek, near Sharpsburg.

In a single day — September 17, 1862 — about 23,000 men were killed, wounded, or missing. It remains the deadliest one-day battle in American history. The battle was a draw, but Lee retreated back to Virginia, letting the Union claim just enough of a victory.

Confederate dead in a row near the Dunker Church, Antietam — photograph by Alexander Gardner, September 1862, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Dead of Antietam

ALEXANDER GARDNER · SEPTEMBER 1862

Days after the battle, photographers walked the field before the dead were buried. No American had ever been allowed to see images like these.

Confederate dead in a row near the Dunker Church, Antietam — photograph by Alexander Gardner, September 1862, public domain (Library of Congress).

“The Dead of Antietam”

OCTOBER 1862 · NEW YORK CITY

A few weeks later, photographer Mathew Brady opened an exhibition in New York City titled “The Dead of Antietam.” For the first time, ordinary Americans — far from any battlefield — stood face to face with photographs of their own countrymen lying dead in the fields.

There was no filter, no heroic painting, no flattering lithograph. Just the bodies, exactly as the camera found them. The public was stunned.

Confederate dead along the Hagerstown Pike fence, Antietam — photograph by Alexander Gardner, September 1862, public domain (Library of Congress).

THE NEW YORK TIMES, ON BRADY'S EXHIBITION · 1862

Mr. Brady has done something to bring home to us the terrible reality and earnestness of war. If he has not brought bodies and laid them in our dooryards … he has done something very like it.

Along the Hagerstown Pike

ALEXANDER GARDNER · SEPTEMBER 1862

Gardner sometimes photographed the same dead from several angles — and historians have shown he occasionally moved objects, or even a body, to compose a stronger picture. Even 'honest' evidence has an author.

Confederate dead along the Hagerstown Pike fence, Antietam — photograph by Alexander Gardner, September 1862, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Dunker Church

THE LANDMARK THEY FOUGHT FOR

A small whitewashed church of a German Baptist sect sat at the heart of the morning's fighting. The cornfields around it changed hands again and again.

The Dunker Church, Antietam battlefield — photograph, September 1862, public domain (Library of Congress).

Lincoln Comes to the Field

OCTOBER 1862

Two weeks later Lincoln visited the army and pressed a cautious General McClellan to pursue Lee. McClellan delayed — and Lincoln soon removed him from command.

President Lincoln with General McClellan and officers at Antietam — photograph by Alexander Gardner, October 1862, public domain (Library of Congress).

Twin Turning Points

WHY IT MATTERS

Antietam changed the war twice over. On the battlefield, Lee's retreat gave Lincoln the victory he had been waiting for — five days later he issued the preliminary Emancipation Proclamation.

And in Brady's gallery, the photograph changed how war itself would be remembered. From now on, the camera — not just the painter — would tell the story. A battlefield could no longer be hidden behind glory.

President Lincoln with General McClellan and officers at Antietam — photograph by Alexander Gardner, October 1862, public domain (Library of Congress).

Read the Camera as Evidence

YOUR TURN

You'll examine Gardner's photographs the way a historian examines any source — asking what they prove, what they leave out, and whether a 'true' photograph can still be shaped by its maker.